

56. On the southeast coasts of the United States, the warm temperate zone extends to the Mississippi River and over the Gulf Coast; the zone is strongly influenced by the warm, moist tropical air mass that originates over the Gulf of Mexico. The long frost-free season exceeds 200 days. Tropical air spreads north in February and dominates the region until November, when polar continental air occasionally invades. Winters are mild, with January means of 40 to 54°F (4 to 12°C). July averages are tropical, with highs exceeding 80°F (28°C).
57. In the American Southwest a Mediterranean type of climate is found. Summers are dry there, because tropical continental air is dominant.
    Central America, with its tropical humid climate, has no real winter; even the coldest month averages above 64°F (18°C).
    On the southeast coasts of the United States, the warm temperate zone extends to the Mississippi River and over the Gulf Coast.
58. A long growing season, moderate temperatures, and a heavy, constant supply of moisture have combined to foster the tallest and largest trees found in North America. Redwood and western cedar along the north coast of California give way to Douglas fir and western hemlock from Oregon to British Columbia and Sitka spruce in Alaska.
59. **The Laurentian mixed forest:**
    Lying in the warm-summer region of the cool temperate zone, the Laurentian mixed forest occurs in the Great Lakes-St. Lawrence, the upper MississippiOhio, and the New England lowland regions. It consists mainly of deciduous hardwoods-maple, beech, oak,